

Looking back, I can clearly see how much my understanding of counseling and my professional identity has evolved through direct clinical experience. At the time, my focus was heavily centered on foundational skills such as SOLER, empathy, active listening, and building rapport. I understood these concepts well in theory and took pride in my ability to demonstrate them in structured mock sessions. My perspective of counseling was more idealistic, emphasizing skill execution and the importance of creating a safe, supportive environment for clients. Now, after working with real clients in a clinical setting, I see that counseling is far more complex and less structured than I originally thought. While those foundational skills remain essential, I have learned that their application is fluid and must adapt to each client's needs, readiness, and level of trust. I have also gained a deeper awareness of how much emotional energy counseling requires, and how important self-awareness, supervision, and boundaries are in sustaining effectiveness over time.

One of the biggest shifts in my perspective has been understanding that being a “good counselor” is not just about technique, but about presence, judgment, and authenticity in real-time moments that cannot be rehearsed. I also now recognize the weight of ethical decision-making and the emotional impact of sitting with clients' struggles consistently over time.

Overall, I have moved from viewing counseling as a set of skills to viewing it as an ongoing process of relationship-building, self-reflection, and adaptability. While I still value the core principles I learned early on, my experience has grounded them in reality and deepened my understanding of what it truly means to sit with and support another person in their healing process.